maize were the main crops. During the latter half of October, the Monpas were busy harvesting and stacking both the maize and the chillies, adding spectacular splashes of colour to the villages.

From Dirang Dzong they followed the established route over Se-la before dropping down to Jang and the Tawang Chu, after which they climbed up once again to Tawang. Despite having traversed some of the most daunting territory on the planet for over five months, Morshead and Bailey were not yet finished. The area west of Tawang bordering Bhutan still needed to be surveyed, plus some members of their party had been left behind in Tibet.

The survey party followed the established trade route from Tawang to Lumla, then turned north along the Nyamjang Chu and crossed back into Tibet at Khenzemane. There are some romantic stories about Morshead having been smitten by a Monpa girl. Whatever the actual reasons, they did not survey either the Tsangdhar Ridge or the Thagla Ridge, and erroneously marked the Nam Ka Chu that flowed in from the tri-junction with Bhutan, as flowing north to south rather than west to east. This thin strip, the Nam ka Chu Valley—approximately 14 kilometres in length and entirely uninhabited—would later become infamous. After collecting the remaining members of their party, the expedition retraced its steps, following the route over Se-la and Dirang Dzong before returning to the Assam plains.

There are certain other aspects of the Morshead-Bailey expedition that need to be highlighted. The party set out from Mipi in mid-May and completed the journey in six months. This was most remarkable, for a similar run on the southern side of the Himalayas would simply not have been feasible. While on the Tibetan axis the party had to move along the Tsangpo from Assam, owing to the north-south orientation of all major river valleys—Lohit, Dibang, Siang, Subansiri, Kameng and Manas—getting from one to the other was almost impossible. Hence, should there be a military confrontation with Tibet (or China or Russia), defending the watershed from the south would be a herculean task.

Second, the Chinese shadow would always loom over Tibet, especially the Kham region. Already the Nepal-Tibet and Sikkim-Bhutan confrontations had seen Chinese intervention in the past. Whatever Tibetan sentiments may have been, they simply did not have a geographical barrier like the Himalayas on their eastern flank or the military ability to keep the Chinese out indefinitely.